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For the President
4 September 2026

Today's Brief

IRAN: US and Iran trade strikes; Tehran hits Gulf bases as oil and the Strait of Hormuz absorb the shock.

UKRAINE: Kyiv lands its deepest naval-drone strike yet, hitting a Russian vessel at Sochi.

ISRAEL-GAZA: Israeli ministers press Washington to back a Gaza 'emigration' plan as West Bank violence continues.

HIMALAYA: Nepal-China glacial-flood toll tops 1,200; hydropower losses point to systemic risk.

PENTAGON: The Army secretary's resignation deepens turmoil at the top of the Defense Department.

VENEZUELA: US locks in Venezuelan oil and takes a direct government stake in post-Maduro Caracas.

NOTES: Lebanon detainee handover; Taiwan Strait incursions resume; a US carrier ends a long war deployment.

For the President
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US-Iran Fighting Escalates as Tehran Strikes Gulf Bases; Hormuz and Oil Markets Absorb the Shock

We assess the direct US-Iran exchange has entered its most dangerous phase since the summer, with Iran striking US-used air bases in Kuwait and the United Arab Emirates in retaliation for American strikes near the Strait of Hormuz, and with neither side signaling an off-ramp. President Trump said Washington could strike Iran “any time we want,” while Vice President Vance declined to put a timeline on the fighting or to characterize it as a war. We judge further tit-for-tat exchanges are likely in the coming days; for Washington, the central risk is a miscalculation that draws Gulf partners deeper in or interrupts the strait outright.

- Iran’s military said it struck Ahmad al-Jaber Air Base in Kuwait and Al Minhad Air Base in the UAE with missiles and drones, following attacks it claimed on 2-3 September; UAE authorities reported three foreign workers killed and 58 injured. Jordan earlier intercepted 10 of 13 ballistic missiles and Bahrain downed drones aimed at a military site.
- The exchange followed US strikes on 1 September against IRGC air-defense and mine-laying targets near Hormuz — which Washington tied to an Iranian attempt to mine the strait — reported to have killed at least 11. Tehran claims a US strike the same evening hit a wedding in Sirik, Hormozgan, causing dozens of casualties; Vance said he was “extremely skeptical” the strike hit a wedding, and Iran’s Red Crescent has asked the ICC to investigate. We treat the civilian-casualty figures as Iranian claims pending independent confirmation.
- For Washington, the near-term decision point is whether to expand the target set inside Iran if attacks on Gulf bases persist. We assess Trump has signaled he is prepared to do so, warning Iran would be “hit much harder” if it retaliates again.

The economic shock is already large. Brent traded near \$96 a barrel and US crude climbed toward \$92 — up roughly 9 percent on the week — as shippers thinned traffic through Hormuz. Overhead imagery indicates transits through the strait fell sharply at midweek, from more than 20 daily crossings to about 10, before partially recovering under US naval escort. The International Energy Agency has called the disruption one of the largest in the history of the global oil market.

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- Energy Secretary Chris Wright said a record 17 million barrels moved through Hormuz on Monday under US military protection — an effort to steady markets even as insurers and tanker operators pull back.
- We assess sustained fighting keeps a war-risk premium embedded in crude and raises the odds of a US pump-price spike into the autumn. An actual closure of the strait, which we still judge unlikely but not negligible, would be a global supply event.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from CIA, DIA, NSA, NGA, the Office of Naval Intelligence, and open sources.

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Ukraine Extends Naval-Drone Reach to Sochi in Its Deepest Black Sea Strike Yet

We assess Kyiv's first known uncrewed-surface-vessel strike on Sochi — roughly 560 kilometers from the nearest Ukrainian-held coast — marks a meaningful extension of its ability to hold Russia's Black Sea rear at risk, and is likely intended to stretch Russian coastal defenses and disrupt naval and energy logistics far from the front.

- Ukraine's Navy said a sea drone struck the Russian-flagged support vessel Nefrit in Sochi harbor on 3 September; Kyiv describes the ship as servicing offshore oil-and-gas and naval infrastructure. Overnight into 4 September, open-source video geolocated to central Sochi showed a fire at an oil depot near the port after an aerial attack.
- Along the front, Ukraine's General Staff reported 199 combat engagements on 3 September, and Russia launched some 163 drones overnight; a strike on Odesa injured eight and damaged a multistory residential building.
- We judge these deep strikes will not by themselves shift the ground war, but they impose real costs on Russia's Black Sea Fleet and its energy exports and signal that no rear-area port is now a sanctuary. Watch for Russian air-defense redeployments toward the Caucasus coast.

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Israeli Ministers Press Washington on Gaza 'Emigration' Plan as West Bank Violence Continues

We assess a push by senior Israeli ministers to win US backing for the large-scale departure of Palestinians from Gaza will sharpen an already difficult choice for Washington, testing the administration's leverage over an Israeli government it continues to arm and shield diplomatically.

- Defense Minister Israel Katz said on 3 September there is “no real solution for Gaza without migration” and that he is seeking President Trump’s support; National Security Minister Itamar Ben Gvir unveiled a plan, styled “Disengagement 710,” envisioning the removal of some 250,000 Gazans in a first year and far more thereafter.
- A group of Senate Democrats released a report accusing Prime Minister Netanyahu’s government of implementing a plan to “ethnically cleanse” Gaza — a sign the issue is hardening along partisan lines in Washington.
- In the West Bank, Israeli fire killed two Palestinian teenagers, aged 19 and 16, during a confrontation with settlers on 3 September; a drone strike in Gaza City’s Rimal district killed at least one more person.

For Washington, the risk is ownership: any perceived US endorsement of forced displacement would carry legal and diplomatic costs and strain ties with Arab partners whose cooperation the United States needs elsewhere, not least against Iran. We expect the administration to keep public distance while the internal Israeli debate plays out, and to resist language that could be read as an endorsement.

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Himalayan Flood Disaster Tops 1,200 Dead; Hydropower Losses Point to Systemic Risk

We assess the glacial-flood catastrophe on the Nepal-China border is now among the deadliest natural disasters in the region in years, with the confirmed toll surpassing 1,200 and thousands still missing a week on — and with damage to Himalayan hydropower that carries longer-term economic and strategic implications for both countries.

- A glacial-lake outburst last week sent rock, ice, and meltwater down border valleys; officials now report more than 1,200 dead, the great majority on the Nepali side, with thousands unaccounted for. Roughly 900 workers are missing from about a dozen damaged hydropower projects, several hundred believed trapped in tunnels.
- Nepal's prime minister, Balendra "Balen" Shah — at 36 one of the world's youngest serving heads of government — tied the disaster to climate change and pressed for international action on mitigation.
- We judge the destruction of border hydropower will strain Nepal's power supply and its cross-border electricity trade, in which China and India both hold stakes, and will renew scrutiny of glacial-lake risks across the Himalayas. For the United States, the episode underscores climate-driven instability in a strategically contested region where Beijing and New Delhi compete for influence.

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Army Secretary's Exit Deepens Turmoil at the Top of the Pentagon

We assess the resignation of Army Secretary Dan Driscoll, amid an open rift with Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth, points to significant turbulence in the Pentagon's civilian and uniformed leadership at a moment when US forces are actively engaged against Iran.

- Driscoll, who at 38 had been the youngest-ever Army secretary, stepped down this week after clashes over blocked modernization efforts and Hegseth's dismissal of senior officers, including the Army chief of staff; several Republican lawmakers have publicly called for Hegseth's removal.
- The department has also moved to disband an Army unit in Europe set up to study Ukraine's battlefield drone innovations — a step we assess could slow US adoption of hard-won lessons from that war.
- On 3 September the White House nominated Hung Cao to serve as Navy secretary.

We judge repeated senior departures and firings risk eroding continuity in force modernization and in civil-military norms. The near-term question for the President is whether the churn affects readiness while multiple crises run at once.

Prepared by ODNI with reporting from DIA, INR, and open sources.

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US Locks In Venezuelan Oil, Taking a Direct Stake in Post-Maduro Caracas

We assess a wave of US-brokered energy deals in Venezuela — headlined by a \$7 billion Chevron commitment and, unusually, a direct US government equity stake in a partner oil venture — cements Washington's economic hold over Caracas eight months after the US operation that removed Nicolas Maduro from power, and adds a modest new source of Western-aligned crude at a moment of acute Gulf supply risk.

- Energy Secretary Chris Wright announced the agreements on Wednesday at the Miraflores palace alongside interim President Delcy Rodriguez; Chevron pledged more than \$7 billion over five years to roughly double its Venezuelan output to about 600,000 barrels per day.
- The Defense Department was granted a 35 percent equity stake in a private venture, North American Blue Energy Partners, which received 100-year concessions to 17 Venezuelan oilfields — an atypical direct US commercial position in a foreign oil sector.
- Maduro, captured in January and facing US narcotics charges, this week sought dismissal of the case on foreign-leader immunity grounds.

We assess the arrangement gives Washington durable leverage over a major reserve base and incremental supply as Hormuz risk climbs, but it also ties the United States directly to the stability of an unelected interim government and invites legal and sovereignty challenges. We would watch production-ramp timelines and any domestic Venezuelan backlash as the leading indicators of whether the bet pays off.

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Notes

- **Lebanon.** Israel handed over a group of Lebanese detainees on 3 September in a transfer the United States said its mediation produced — a modest confidence-building step as Washington presses Israel-Lebanon de-escalation. We assess it is a tactical gesture rather than a sign of a broader settlement.
- **Taiwan Strait.** Taiwan's defense ministry tracked 17 PLA aircraft crossing the Strait median line into its air-defense identification zone, with several PLA Navy ships operating nearby, on 3 September — activity that has picked up after a months-long lull. We judge it consistent with routine pressure signaling rather than preparation for imminent action.
- **US Navy.** The carrier USS Abraham Lincoln pulled into Thailand for its first shore leave after 286 days at sea, an unusually long wartime deployment tied to sustained Middle East operations; crew accounts cited strains on supplies and morale, a reminder of the readiness costs of the current operational tempo.

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